'AB has great potential,' Oom Derek would tell my parents, 'and he ought to train every day, but he must never stop enjoying the game. There should always be time for an ice cream.'

The advice made sense then, and it still makes sense all these years later. However high the stakes, sport must always retain an element of enjoyment – even if, in time, the ice creams did become beers.

When Oom Derek retired as a coach, my mother started to take me and a few other young players to attend a one-week tennis clinic run by Theuns van Rensburg in the town of Bethlehem in the Free State. It was a demanding schedule, with tennis starting at 7 am every morning and running through until 5 pm in the evening. Oom Theuns had introduced the Nick Bollettieri method of coaching to South Africa and, at one stage, the renowned American coach actually attended the course in Bethlehem.

So, after playing in the Lowveld Open in 1990, aged six, I joined the year-round programme of age-group tennis tournaments played throughout South Africa. The Northern Transvaal Open was our 'home' event, played at Groenkloof in Pretoria, and we invariably drove to compete in both the Southern Transvaal Open in Johannesburg and the Eastern Transvaal Open in Benoni. December and January brought even longer car journeys to compete on the so-called Sugar Circuit, incorporating the Free State Open in Bloemfontein, the Natal Open in Durban, the Border Open in East London, the Eastern Province Open in Port Elizabeth and the Western Province Open in Cape Town.

Endless hours on the road brought two challenges: car sickness, which I simply needed to bear, and what became an intense fear of getting stuck in traffic, arriving late and being disqualified.

'How long till we get there?' I used to whine *ad nauseam*.

On one occasion, we were severely delayed by a traffic jam on the N1 between Pretoria and Johannesburg and, somewhat flustered, we arrived at the Ellis Park courts to hear my name being called on the